LETTER FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Real fortunes are sometimes made in twists of fortune. Of late, the Indian art market seems to have become the stage for such dramatic transformations. In the middle of March, Christie's sold Maqbool Fida Husain's Untitled *Gram Yatra* for $13.75 million (₹119 crore), smashing all previous records, to become the most expensive Modern Indian painting ever sold. Ashish Anand, CEO and Managing Director, DAG (formerly Delhi Art Gallery) estimates the total size of the Indian art market at around ₹3,000 crore. "The total value of the Indian art market at the turn of the century was the value of just one painting today," says Anand, adding that while the market has grown significantly over the last 25 years, the real growth will come now: "By 2030, I expect the Indian art market to be around ₹10,000 crore."

If the art market in the country is at a tipping point, the whisky industry has been no less transformational. In late February this year, Amrut released the oldest single malt ever made in this country, with an unprecedented 15-year maturation period in a limited edition of just 75 bottles. The price of the Amrut Expedition at US$ 12,000 (₹10.3 lakh approx.) presented a landmark moment in India's whisky history, especially since the usual price of a 15YO single malt whisky from famed brands such as Glenfiddich 15 or The Macallan Double Cask 15 rests affordably between $80-$150 (₹6,900-12,956). This twist of fate moment has indeed been one to toast for the Indian alco-bev sector, long dismissed as a haven of unrefined and cost-effective products.

Age statements don't just represent a glory moment for whisky, but for the newly restored 230-year-old Chettiar mansion, THE Lotus Palace, too. The Park Hotels has forayed into the restoration of this heritage property, sensitively maintaining its original maximalist aesthetic, while adding modern conveniences. Even as the Lotus Palace blooms brightly on the tourist map to prove that old is indeed gold, fashion veteran Giorgio Armani is on the cusp of a second coming at 90. Old and venerable he may be, but he is definitely the new kid on the block, returning to New York, after an 11-year hiatus, to open his new project at 760 Madison Avenue. Not only does this hybrid space have his store, which houses the women's and men's collections and accessories, his interiors collection (Armani Casa), but even a forthcoming Armani restaurant and ten Armani-designed apartments (all of which have already been pre-sold).

If Armani's clothes are fashionable again, the fortunes of bread seem to be on the rise too. This simple and enduring staple is now The Dish, with handcrafted artisanal loaves. Speciality bake houses are now experimenting with various flours, flavours and techniques; in fact, some bakeries are even commissioning, mixing and often times milling their own flours to create the perfect loaf, pursuing the concept of terroir.

Clearly, bread is living up to its destiny as 'manna from heaven'. Our multi-star cover also summons three extraordinary women who have recast themselves in fabulous new roles breaking convention, norm and expectation. Much like them, the *Spice* issue too aims to engage and inspire.





● Giorgio Armani RTW Spring 2025 (Above); **The 15-year-old whisky**, Amrut Expedition has inspired a revaluation of ageing among Indian whiskies (Top)

(Aroon Purie)